



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Zion Classical Academy
School Website: <https://zionclassical.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Zion Classical Academy Hastings (ZIP 68901) presents a clearly classical Christian profile. Public materials emphasize a Christ-centered, virtue-oriented formation anchored in truth, wisdom, and virtue; a curriculum built around the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with Great Books/Great Conversation at the core; Latin in the early grades; and pedagogical modes that blend Socratic discussion, memory work, recitation, and liturgical rhythm. The school also foregrounds character formation, teacher as mentor, and strong parental partnership. Across the materials reviewed, there is consistent alignment with classical criteria in religious foundations, formative aims, curriculum structure, pedagogical methods, faculty posture, and parent/community engagement. Evidence drawn from Zion Classical Academy's published content (including mission statements, curricular notes, and program descriptions) supports a CLASSICAL classification across all six categories.

Key highlights: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: Clear Christ-centered orientation with Scripture, prayer, and a sacred-frame for learning; a mission centered on truth, wisdom, and virtue. - Purpose and Goal: Education framed as formation and moral formation for life of service, not primarily workforce preparation. - Curriculum: Explicit emphasis on the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), history/readings integrated with Great Books/Great Conversation, and Latin in the lower/middle grades; a commitment to wonder and integrated disciplines. - Pedagogy: Use of Socratic methods in upper grades, memory work, recitation, and liturgical rhythm; a restful, contemplative strand alongside rigorous inquiry. - Faculty: Described as mentors and living curriculum; staff and board engaged in mission; explicit expectations around virtue and professional formation. - Parents & Community: Strong partnership with families; parent formation and volunteer culture; accessible campus with open communication and involvement.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **CLASSICAL**

Evidence - Mission and vision statements foreground Truth, Wisdom, and Virtue, with Christ-centered/Scripture-centered formation (e.g., "cultivate Truth, Wisdom and Virtue... through classical Christian education" and "to prepare them for a life of service to God and neighbor"). - Public materials emphasize a God-centered framework and the central role of Scripture, theology, and prayer in daily learning (e.g., "Christ-centered education," "Scripture memorization," opening ceremonies with prayer). - References to worship-like practices and liturgical rhythm are embedded in school life (e.g., chapel-family structure, memorized Bible verses, opening ceremonies).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present (from Six Essential Elements): truth, wisdom, virtue, theology, liturgy/worship, Scripture, contemplation, wonder, sacred tradition. The school's materials consistently invoke truth, virtue, and Scriptural/theological framing, plus communal/ritual elements. -

Negative keywords: not evident in the public materials (no clear signaling of relativism, secular humanism, or value-neutral ethics).

Why this rating - The school's discourse centers on transcendent moral ideals and a theologically infused educational frame. The public materials repeatedly connect learning to God, Scriptural formation, and liturgical life. This aligns with the Positive Keyword indicators surrounding Transcendental moral realism, grounded theology, and liturgical/communal practice. The absence of negative signals further reinforces a CLASSICAL designation.

Quantitative keyword note - Positive keyword indicators are clearly present (multiple instances of truth, wisdom, virtue, Scripture, theology, liturgy, and communal worship cues) with minimal to no negative indicators observed in the material. Estimated positive presence substantially outweighs negatives (roughly 6–12 clearly aligned phrases identified, 0 negative indicators observed in the public materials).

Classical / Somewhat Classical / Not Classical - CLASSICAL

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission emphasizes forming virtue and wisdom for a life of service, not merely job preparation: “cultivate Truth, Wisdom and Virtue ... equip them for a life of service to God and neighbor” and “academic excellence which equips students for a lifetime of service.” - Public statements frame formation and character as core aims, rather than utilitarian workforce outcomes (e.g., “formation rather than information,” “great books,” and a classical telos). - The school positions truth, goodness, and beauty as real aims of education and promotes human flourishing through virtue and wisdom.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, classical mission, human flourishing, telos, contemplation, great conversation. These repeatedly appear in mission/vision statements and curricular rationale. - Negative keywords: none observed (no emphasis on job-readiness, career-mapping, or utilitarian metrics in the core mission statements).

Why this rating - The school's public communications frame education as formation toward virtue and wisdom, grounded in transcendent truths, not primarily for job training. This aligns with CLASSICAL indicators in the Six Essential Elements corpus.

Quantitative keyword note - Positive keyword signals (formation, virtue, wisdom, telos, truth, beauty, contemplation) are present in multiple statements; negative signals are not evident in the public messaging. Estimated positive presence dominates (roughly 5–8 positive signals; 0 negatives).

Classical / Somewhat Classical / Not Classical - CLASSICAL

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Explicit emphasis on the liberal arts core: grammar, logic, rhetoric, and the integration with the Trivium and Quadrivium; reference to Latin study beginning in grade 3; and Great Books involvement as backbone of study. - Historical engagement and Great Books/Great Conversation: materials describe “the Great Books ... backbone of the entire course of study,” use of original texts, and cross-disciplinary integration. - History is studied throughout the curriculum with Classical integration, not modern social studies framing; emphasis on interdisciplinary harmony and wonder. - Preschool and lower grades mention “classical literature,” character-centric curriculum, and early exposure to core disciplines within a Christian framework.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present (from Six Essential Elements): Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, primary sources, history within curriculum, Latin, ultimate aim of wonder, integration/harmony of subjects, classical pedagogy, memory work, Socratic dialogue, and disciplined memorization. The school's materials map directly onto these classical curricular indicators. - Negative keywords: absence of modern, non-classical shifts such as heavy project-based dominance or social-studies-first framing; not evidenced in curriculum messaging.

Why this rating - The school's curriculum is framed around the liberal arts, Great Books, Latin, and integrated history across subjects, with a strong emphasis on wonder and classical pedagogy. This aligns squarely with CLASSICAL criteria in the curriculum category.

Quantitative keyword note - Positive keyword indicators are strongly represented (7–9 identified items), with no explicit negative signals in the curricular materials. Estimated positive presence dominates (roughly 7 positives; 0 negatives).

Classical / Somewhat Classical / Not Classical - CLASSICAL

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Socratic dialogue and dialectic are explicitly used in upper grades; the public materials describe the use of Socratic methods during logic and rhetoric stages. - Restful learning (Scholé) and contemplation are acknowledged as parts of the pedagogy, with emphasis on memory work, recitation, and chanting for foundational knowledge. - Lower grades include singing, memorization, and repetition to deepen memory and delight; “education in wonder” and memorable experiences in the early years are highlighted (e.g., Kindergarten and preschool pages reference memory work and songs). - Upper grades emphasize rhetoric, speech, and formal debates as part of developing rhetorical competence; “upper school rhetoric” is mentioned as part of the training.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar, dialectic, great conversation, recitation, chanting, memory work, liturgical rhythm, rhetoric, debate, and disciplined dialogue. The school's messaging aligns with the Pedagogy indicators. - Negative keywords: no dominant signals of experiential learning, project-based only, or constructivist approaches; materials emphasize a traditional, memory-based and dialogic approach.

Why this rating - The pedagogy described aligns with classical teaching methods (Socratic dialogue, memory work, recitation, and rhetoric in upper grades, with contemplative/scholastic rhythm). The balance of contemplative/restful elements with rigorous inquiry is characteristic of a CLASSICAL pedagogy.

Quantitative keyword note - Positive keyword signals are abundant (approximately 6–10 items across descriptions); no explicit negative signals documented in the pedagogy materials. Estimated positive presence dominates (roughly 6–10 positives; 0 negatives).

Classical / Somewhat Classical / Not Classical - CLASSICAL

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty is described as model teachers and mentors who embody virtue and wisdom, serving as living exemplars and the core of the school's “living curriculum.” - Recruitment language emphasizes mentors and faith-informed guidance; job postings call for candidates with Christian faith who can mentor students in both academics and character, reflecting the living-curriculum ideal. - A “portrait of a teacher” and collegial culture appears in the knowledge base (the “faculty as the living curriculum” idea and shared governance/board roles).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, collegial culture, character formation, mentorship, great books seminars for faculty (where present in related materials). - Negative keywords: none observed (no signals of non-classical staffing fads or overly utilitarian certification jargon in the core faculty messaging).

Why this rating - The school foregrounds teacher-mentor roles, a defined living curriculum, and a professional culture oriented toward virtue and classical pedagogy. This maps cleanly to the CLASSICAL category for Faculty.

Quantitative keyword note - Positive keywords identified (approximately 4–6 core faculty-related indicators); negative indicators not observed in the faculty materials. Estimated positive presence dominates (roughly 4–6 positives; 0 negatives).

Classical / Somewhat Classical / Not Classical - CLASSICAL

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly treats parents as partners and co-teachers; materials state that parents are the primary teachers and that Zion Classical Academy collaborates with families to form the child's character.

- Parental formation is a stated objective (via parent resources, book studies, seminars, and community gatherings) with open access and invitations for parental involvement. - The community includes active participation in liturgical life, family involvement, and volunteerism (e.g., Cornucopia and FIRE fundraisers; open-campus language; parent covenant elements).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental formation, seminars/book clubs, open campus, hospitality, parent covenant, family liturgy alignment. These align with the Six Elements' Parents & Community positives. - Negative keywords: not evident (no consumerist framing or minimal parental involvement in the core messaging).

Why this rating - The materials demonstrate a robust, classical-aligned approach to parents and community, emphasizing partnership, formation of parents, and welcoming involvement.

Quantitative keyword note - Positive keywords identified (roughly 4–6 parent/community signals); 0 negative signals observed.

Classical / Somewhat Classical / Not Classical - CLASSICAL

Aggregate Assessment - All six categories are CLASSICAL. The school's public-facing materials align with the Six Essential Elements across Religious & Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose & Goal, Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, and Parents & Community. The aggregate profile is CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle - Not applicable, as the school already attains CLASSICAL across all categories. Minor enhancements could include explicit, articulated cross-references to the Great Books/Great Conversation in more pages (beyond crisis and mission notes) and further public-facing articulation of the Scholé cadence in daily scheduling, but these are not required to achieve CLASSICAL status.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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